Akbar was greatly accessible to his people, as Father Monserrate noted; and he made his court open to diverse talent, as his Uzbek and Central Asian warlords complained. But his trust was less easy to obtain, and impossible to regain.

There is a clear example in Badauni's own life. Though the disillusioned scholar bemoans his failure to rise in court – poor I! – and blames it on his inability to flatter as Abul Fazl could, there is enough evidence in his own writing to suggest that Badauni was faring fairly well until he lost Akbar's trust. He had pleased the emperor with his enthusiasm for war in Haldighati; his dulcet tones had gained him the post of imam at the mosque; and his various translations had been well received. But Badauni was a restless soul. First, he wanted to go on the Haj, but Abdun Nabi wouldn't allow it because Badauni had a mother to take care of. Sometime later, he lost a son, a shock that further undermined his commitment to his job. Eventually, Badauni took five months off, but stayed away a full year. When he returned, Akbar had lost interest in him. 'Even to this day although a period of eighteen years has elapsed since that event, and eighteen thousand worlds have passed away', wrote Badauni, he had no 'chance of confirming myself in [the emperor's] favour'.

With Birbar, on the other hand, it was, as Badauni puts it, 'a case of "Thy flesh is my flesh, and thy blood my blood"'. How it must have plagued Akbar, then, to know that it was he who sent his friend to his death.

And yet, at the time, it was an honour Birbar craved.

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In February 1586, at about the time that Bhagwant Das was ready to return from Kashmir, Zain Khan sent a request for reinforcements. He was far west of the valley fighting the Afghans of Swat and Bajaur and, after twenty-three battles, Zain wrote to say that his men were 'somewhat worn out'.[21]

Immediately, Abul Fazl volunteered for the job. He wanted, he writes, to 'shut the mouths of . . . envious persons' who were being snide, presumably, about his lack of military experience. Debating theology in the evenings might well please Akbar and win promotions, but a man was still only a man with a sword in his hand. It may have been for similar reasons that